

Ottonian

The Ottonian style of architecture evolved during the reign of Holy Roman Emperor Otto the Great (936–75 CE). Following on from Carolingian, it developed in Germany and lasted from the mid-10th until the mid-11th century. Like Carolingian, Ottonian contributed to the wider Romanesque style. Among other traits, it adopted the Carolingian double-ended variation on the Roman basilica, with apses at both ends of the nave rather than just one. Ottonian builders retained the huge Carolingian westworks and outer crypts, but the architecture was generally simpler, more systematic and monumental.

Saint Michael's in Hildesheim, Lower Saxony (founded c.1001) embodies the style, with two crypts, two apses and two transepts – each with a square crossing tower – in a geometric arrangement. The Ottonians also developed heavy columns and piers, wall arcades and blind arches around windows. Proportions were nevertheless simple and balanced, with careful attention paid to mathematical harmony.



Church of St Cyriacus, Frose, Germany, c.960